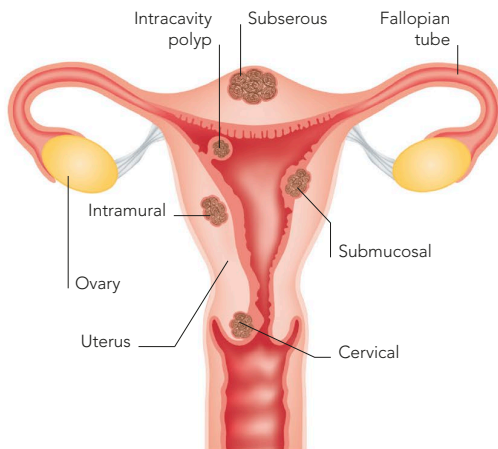


FIBROIDS

Fibroids are very common, occurring in about one-third of women of childbearing age. They can occur singly or in groups, and can be the size of a pea or as large as a grapefruit. Small fibroids are unlikely to cause any problems. Larger ones may result in prolonged and heavy menstrual bleeding, and increasingly severe period pain. Large fibroids can distort the uterus, which may cause infertility, or put pressure on other organs, such as the bladder or rectum.

SITES AND TYPES OF FIBROIDS

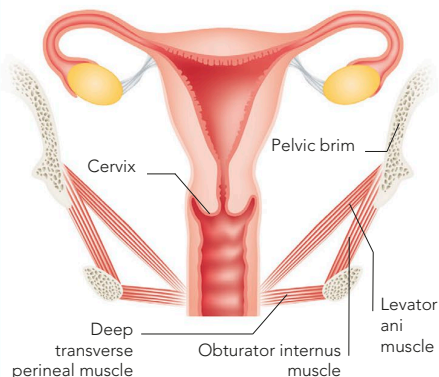
Fibroids can occur in any part of the uterus wall and are named according to their site – for example, in the cervix – or in the tissues they occupy, such as submucosal fibroids.



PROLAPSED UTERUS

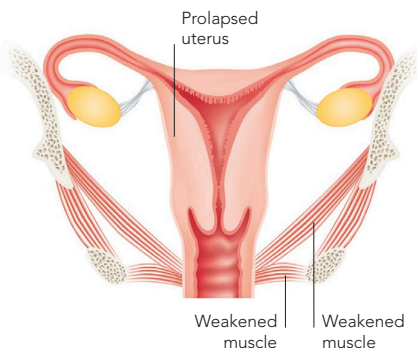
Prolapse of the uterus is more likely to occur after the menopause, when low oestrogen levels affect the ability of the ligaments to retain the uterus. Childbirth, obesity, and straining while coughing or opening the bowels are contributing factors.

The uterus protrudes down into the vagina, and in severe cases may reach as far as the vulva. Symptoms may include a feeling of fullness in the vagina, pain in the lower back, and difficulty passing urine or faeces.



NORMAL UTERUS

The uterus is kept in place by muscles and ligaments. Regular pelvic floor exercises are important to maintain their strength and avoid prolapse.



PROLAPSED UTERUS

In this case of uterine prolapse, the uterus has slipped down into the vagina because of weakened muscles. The wall of the vagina may also prolapse.